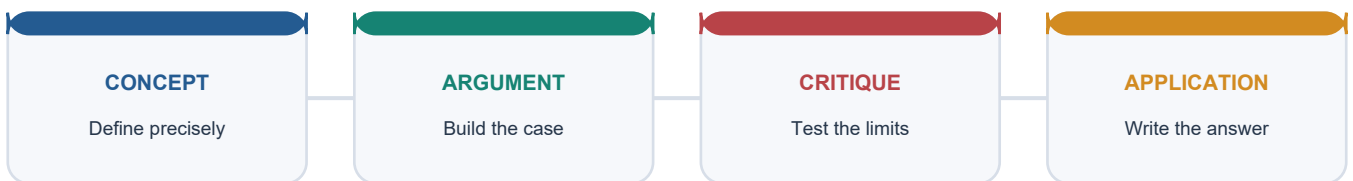


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Issue-Based Prompt Scoping - Complete Essay Knowledge Guide

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Issue-Based Prompt Scoping - Complete Essay Knowledge Guide

Essay-specific learner-v2 contract: one continuous knowledge guide, one question-only workbook and one separate solutions document. No artificial learning-session sequence and no MCQs.

EASY-FIRST ROUTE AND ESSAY DEMAND

Purpose: Issue-Based Prompt Scoping owns one stage of the Essay workflow. Learn the exact demand first, practise the stage in isolation, then reconnect it to thesis, paragraph unity, counter-view and conclusion.

Stage	Learner question	Output
Understand	What relationship does the prompt assert?	Plain-language restatement
Build	What single qualified thesis controls the response?	Thesis + argument map
Develop	What distinct job does each paragraph perform?	Coherent paragraph rail
Test	What is the strongest counter-view or limiting condition?	Qualified synthesis
Finish	Does the conclusion return to the exact proposition?	Earned close



Issue-Based Prompt Scoping workflow atlas

The atlas uses Essay information grammar: demand, idea tree, argument map, evidence, paragraph rail, counter-view and synthesis.

Integrated ASCII workflow

ESSAY WORKFLOW - ISSUE-BASED PROMPT SCOPING

=====

PROMPT -> DEMAND -> THESIS -> ARGUMENT JOBS -> EVIDENCE -> COUNTER-VIEW
-> QUALIFIED SYNTHESIS -> CONCLUSION -> REVISION

PANEL 01/12 - Issue classification gate [decision-tree]

CONCRETE PHENOMENON NAMED?

CAUSAL OR EVALUATIVE CLAIM PRESENT?

LITERAL READING ALREADY CONTESTABLE?

YES -> SCOPE | NO -> DECODE FIRST

|

v

PANEL 02/12 - Demand types [matrix]

QUESTION -> judgment required

ALTERNATIVES -> compare and qualify

CAUSAL ASSERTION -> test links

VALUE CLAIM -> define evaluative standard

|

v

PANEL 03/12 - Object-qualifier lock [firewall]

OBJECT -> exact phenomenon or relationship

QUALIFIER -> named population, place or judgment

THESIS -> must preserve both

DRIFT -> adjacent subject matter without argumentative function

|

v

PANEL 04/12 - Scope coordinates [spatial-map]

WHERE -> geography

WHEN -> time horizon

WHO -> actor

AT WHAT LEVEL -> scale

|

v

PANEL 05/12 - Causal chain test [causal-chain]

ASSERTED CAUSE

MECHANISM -> EVIDENCE

MEDIATOR OR FEEDBACK

LIMIT -> QUALIFIED EFFECT

|

v

PANEL 06/12 - Evaluative standard [comparison-table]

PROMPT WORD -> threat, anomaly, myth or complex

STANDARD -> what would make the judgment true

EVIDENCE -> cases supporting or weakening it

VERDICT -> graded rather than absolute

|

v

PANEL 07/12 - Hidden-tension map [dialectic]

PROMISED BENEFIT

OBSERVED OR ASSERTED COST

CONDITIONS ALTERING THE BALANCE

SYNTHESIS -> responsibility across actors

|

v

PANEL 08/12 - Exclusion box [boundary-map]

IN -> material proving the exact relationship

OUT -> generic history of the whole domain

OUT -> unrelated schemes and statistics

RE-ENTRY -> only with a clear argumentative function

|

v

PANEL 09/12 - Definition-to-thesis bridge [process-flow]

DEFINE NECESSARY TERMS

STATE OBJECT AND QUALIFIERS

NAME CAUSAL OR EVALUATIVE BURDEN

WRITE CONDITIONAL THESIS

|

v

PANEL 10/12 - GS-collapse warning [comparison-table]

GS LIST -> causes, effects, schemes

ESSAY MOVE -> claim, mechanism, counter-case

GS LIST -> parallel headings

ESSAY MOVE -> connected paragraph argument

|

v
 PANEL 11/12 - Counter-case to synthesis [feedback-loop]
 THESIS -> strongest supporting mechanism
 COUNTER-CASE -> rival effect or limit
 CONDITION -> when each side dominates
 SYNTHESIS -> distributed responsibility and feasible action
 |
 v
 PANEL 12/12 - Scoping answer spine [answer-spine]
 CLASSIFY -> DEMAND -> OBJECT -> QUALIFIER
 GEOGRAPHY -> TIME -> ACTOR -> SCALE
 MECHANISM -> TENSION -> EXCLUSIONS
 THESIS -> COUNTER-CASE -> SYNTHESIS
 |
 v
 FINAL CONTROL
 One controlling thesis; each paragraph performs a distinct argument job.
 Examples prove or qualify a claim; they never replace reasoning.
 No invented quotation, statistic, report, author or official rubric.

COMPLETE BASIC KNOWLEDGE

Subject: Essay | **Tier:** Must-Do | **GS Paper:** Essay (General Studies Paper - Essay, Mains). **Core area:** Scoping empirical/social-policy prompts (e.g. the FOMO prompt) as essays, not GS answers - issue framing, boundary-setting, and avoiding scheme-listing. **Grounded in:** UPSC Essay PYQ corpus - V1 directly verified locally for 2018-2025 and V2 carried-forward practice wording for 2013-2017 (see `../PYQ-Corpus-2013-2025.md`); `../00_Master-Framework.md` Section 4. **Research cutoff:** 18 July 2026. **Tags:** FACT: verified fact | ANALYSIS: strategy/inference | CURRENT: dated anchor | WRONG: trap/boundary. **Companion:** `../advanced/03_Issue-Based-Prompt-Scoping.md`

1. Purpose and scope

A clear audited example - 2024-B5, printed as "Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth precipitating depression and loneliness" - is an issue-statement rather than a philosophical aphorism: it names a real phenomenon, a mechanism and a consequence directly. This topic teaches how to scope such prompts as an essay *argument*, distinct from 02's aphorism-decoding and distinct from a GS-III/Society answer.

2. Core terms in plain language

- **Issue-statement prompt:** a prompt that names a real-world phenomenon and asserts a causal or evaluative claim about it, without requiring metaphor-decoding.
- **Scope creep:** letting the essay drift into a general survey of the subject area (e.g. "social media in India") instead of the specific asserted claim.
- **GS-answer collapse:** structuring the essay like a GS-I/II/III answer - headings, "causes/effects/measures taken" lists - rather than a continuous argued essay.

3. FACT: Exam facts / source basis

- FACT: 2024-B5 is printed exactly as: "Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth precipitating depression and loneliness." - no author, and **no comma before "precipitating"** (widely circulated versions insert one; the paper does not). No further qualifying data is attached in the source paper.
- FACT: It is printed as **item 1 of Section B** in the 2024 paper, which restarts Section B numbering at 1; B5 is this folder's internal label (see `../README.md`).
- ANALYSIS: The missing comma slightly changes what is asserted: without it, "precipitating depression and loneliness" reads as attached to the FOMO it triggers rather than as a separate consequence of social media. FACT: Either way the essay must engage the *causal chain the sentence asserts* -

social media -> FOMO -> depression/loneliness - and WRONG: not substitute a general discussion of social media's effects.

- ANALYSIS: Within the 2024-2025 paper pair, this is the only direct, unmetaphorical issue-statement; the remaining 15 prompts are decoded via 02. This is **not** a claim about the whole V1 corpus: 2018-2025 contains further issue and hybrid prompts requiring the same method.

3a. Is this actually an issue prompt? - a three-question test

ANALYSIS: basic/02, Section 3a, gives the full philosophical-vs-issue contrast table. This section does not repeat it; it supplies the decision procedure for the one call you have to make under time pressure.

- Q1 Does the sentence name a real, nameable phenomenon (social media, urbanisation, automation) rather than an abstraction?
no -> philosophical prompt: decode it (02)
yes -> continue
- Q2 Does it assert a causal or evaluative claim ABOUT that phenomenon ("is triggering", "has lost the ability to", "is a threat to")?
no -> a bare topic label, not an issue-statement: treat as a scoping-plus-decoding hybrid, decoding first
yes -> continue
- Q3 Would a literal reading of the sentence already give you something contestable to argue?
yes -> issue prompt: scope it (this file)
no -> the sentence only looks empirical; decode first (02)

ANALYSIS: Q3 is the one candidates skip. 2024-A1 ("Forests precede civilizations and deserts follow them") passes Q1 and arguably Q2, but fails Q3 - read literally it is a claim about vegetation sequence that nobody would spend 1000 words contesting. That failure is the signal that the sentence is carrying a metaphor, and that 02 owns it. WRONG: Scoping a prompt that needed decoding produces a technically accurate essay about the wrong subject - the most expensive error available at this stage, because it is invisible until the essay is finished.

4. The central idea and common misreading

ANALYSIS: **Central idea:** an issue-based prompt still needs a *thesis*, not just an accurate description of the phenomenon - the essay must argue something about the claim (its mechanism, its limits, what follows), not merely narrate it. WRONG: **Common misreading:** treating 2024-B5 as an invitation to write a GS-III/Society-style answer on social media's "causes, effects and government measures" complete with scheme names and headings - this under-uses the essay's actual test of argument and synthesis.

5. Basic decomposition questions

1. What exact claim is being made - connection causes FOMO causes depression/loneliness - and is this an absolute or a tendency claim?
2. What is the mechanism linking cause to effect (e.g. social comparison, curated self-presentation, algorithmic amplification)?
3. Who is most affected, and does the prompt's "youth" framing hold uniformly or need qualification (e.g. by access, platform design, family/school context)?
4. What is the strongest counter-case (e.g. social media also enabling support communities, information access, civic mobilisation)?
5. What synthesis resolves the tension without denying either the harm or the benefit?

5a. Causal-evidence-limit chain

ANALYSIS: Treat each asserted causal link as an argument to test, not as a fact to repeat:

PROMPT CLAIM

- > plausible mechanism
- > named, verifiable evidence or illustration
- > what that evidence supports (not more)
- > mediator, counter-case or limit
- > qualified thesis

An association is not proof of causation. If you cannot name evidence, state the mechanism and the limit qualitatively rather than inventing a statistic or presenting correlation as settled proof.

6. Dimension-expansion grid

Dimension	Content for 2024-B5
Individual/psychological	Social comparison, curated self-image, validation-seeking
Family/community	Parental awareness, peer culture, offline-relationship displacement
Institutional/platform	Algorithmic design incentives, engagement-maximising features
State/policy	Digital literacy programmes, platform accountability debates
Ethical/values	Autonomy vs. protection of minors; free expression vs. harm mitigation

7. India-first illustration starters

ANALYSIS: Recall (not invent) a named, verifiable Indian illustration relevant to youth mental health, digital literacy or student smartphone use. Use it as functional evidence for one dimension above, not as a scheme-listing exercise. Full discipline: 12.

8. Thesis options and selection

ANALYSIS: Sample alternative theses for 2024-B5: (a) social media's design, not connectivity itself, is the primary driver of FOMO-linked distress, implying design/regulatory responses; (b) FOMO reflects a pre-existing social-comparison tendency that technology has amplified rather than created, implying that literacy and self-regulation matter alongside platform reform. Choose the one you can sustain with real illustrations and a genuine counter-case. Full method: 05.

9. Simple essay architecture

ANALYSIS: A workable shape: one paragraph framing the phenomenon and its scale without invented statistics, two to three paragraphs developing distinct mechanisms/dimensions (Section 6), one paragraph testing the counter-case (Section 5, Q4), and a synthesis conclusion (agency + literacy + humane platform design) - not a "conclusion" that merely lists more government schemes. Full architecture: 07.

10. Opening, body and closure moves

ANALYSIS: A safe opening states the tension (connectivity promising closeness while producing isolation) in your own words, without a fabricated anecdote. A safe closing resolves the tension into a forward-looking, feasible synthesis - not a list of five recommendations in bullet form. Full method: 06.

11. WRONG: Traps and repair moves

- WRONG: **Writing a GS-III/Society answer** with headings and a "government measures" list. -> Repair: keep the piece as one continuous argued essay; use 07's paragraph-flow method instead of headings.
 - WRONG: **Treating "youth" as a monolith** ignoring access/context variation. -> Repair: qualify claims by access, platform design, and social context (Section 6).
 - WRONG: **One-sided moralising against social media** without the counter-case. -> Repair: always include Section 5's Q4 counter-case before the synthesis.
 - WRONG: **Citing unverifiable statistics** on depression/loneliness rates.
- > Repair: describe mechanism and pattern in qualitative terms rather than inventing a number (full discipline: 09).

12. Timed micro-drill and self-check

5-minute drill: For 2024-B5, write one sentence each for: the mechanism, the strongest counter-case, and your chosen thesis. Then write one Indian illustration you can genuinely recall (not invent) that functions as evidence for your mechanism.

Transfer drills - unfamiliar prompts: These are practice prompts, not claims supplied as facts.

1. *"Remote work has improved productivity while weakening workplace community."* Identify each causal link, one mediator, one counter-case and the qualified thesis.

2. *"When algorithms choose, responsibility does not disappear."* Decide whether the prompt is issue-based, philosophical or hybrid; then map mechanism -> named evidence -> limit before planning dimensions.

Self-check: Does your plan contain any heading, numbered list, or "government schemes" section that belongs in a GS answer rather than a continuous essay? If yes, remove it and rewrite that portion as connected prose.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md.

- **Years represented:** 2024
- **Paper(s):** Essay
- **Routed question demands:** 2

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (exact V1 wording)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	Essay	Section A - 1	"Forests precede civilizations and deserts follow them."	Essay · about 1000-1200 words; 2024 paper: 125 marks each	Routed to essay-method owner	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2024	Essay	Section B - 1	"Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth precipitating depression and loneliness."	Essay · about 1000-1200 words; 2024 paper: 125 marks each	Routed to essay-method owner	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.

What this owner must now support

- "Forests precede civilizations and deserts follow them."
- "Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth

precipitating depression and loneliness."

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

CORE APPLICATION LAB

Paragraph unity rail

CLAIM -> NAMED EXAMPLE -> MECHANISM -> LIMIT -> BRIDGE TO NEXT CLAIM

A paragraph is not a container for all facts on one dimension. It must advance the thesis through one principal claim, explain the relevance of its evidence and end with a qualification or transition.

Evidence discipline

- Prefer a modest, accurate example to an impressive but uncertain statistic.
- Do not assign an author to an aphorism unless the audited paper prints one.
- Constitutional provisions, judgments, institutions and programmes must be used for a precise proposition, not as ornamental names.
- Cross-GS knowledge should enrich an argument; it must not turn the essay into a catalogue.

Counter-view and synthesis

State the strongest objection fairly, show what it changes, retain the part of the thesis that survives and specify the conditions under which the final claim is defensible.

SOLVED ESSAYS AND MODEL ANSWERS

SOLVED ESSAY 1 - 2018-A1

Prompt

Alternative technologies for a climate change resilient India.

Verification and attribution boundary

Exact V1 wording from the local official paper; used to scope object, qualifier and India boundary. No author is attributed unless the audited paper itself prints one; this model uses no invented quotation, statistic, report or official marking rule.

Prompt interpretation

Identify the operative relation, surface its tension, state the scope and preserve one counter-reading. Do not replace the proposition with a broad GS subject label.

Central thesis

Alternative technologies can strengthen India's climate resilience when they are locally appropriate, affordable and integrated with institutions and community knowledge; technology is an enabler of adaptation, not a substitute for ecological planning or social justice.

Complete outline

1. **Resilient agriculture:** Drought-tolerant crops, micro-irrigation, soil monitoring and weather advisories can reduce climate-sensitive farm losses.
2. **Distributed energy:** Decentralised renewable systems and storage can support essential services when central networks fail.

3. **Water security:** Wastewater reuse, aquifer monitoring, rainwater harvesting and efficient treatment expand local buffers.
4. **Risk information:** Remote sensing, forecasting and last-mile warning systems improve preparedness only when alerts are trusted and actionable.
5. **Climate-resilient settlements:** Cool roofs, passive design, permeable surfaces and nature-based drainage can reduce heat and flood exposure.
6. **Justice and capability:** Open standards, local repair skills, finance and public procurement determine whether vulnerable communities can use the technology.

Full model essay - 1006 words

The statement, "Alternative technologies for a climate change resilient India.", is not an invitation to display every fact associated with its nouns. It asks the writer to identify the relationship asserted by the sentence, test that relationship across different settings and arrive at a qualified judgment. Alternative technologies can strengthen India's climate resilience when they are locally appropriate, affordable and integrated with institutions and community knowledge; technology is an enabler of adaptation, not a substitute for ecological planning or social justice. The essay will therefore move from the central idea to its individual, institutional and public consequences, then confront the strongest limit before returning to an earned synthesis.

To begin with, **resilient agriculture** gives the argument a distinct job. Drought-tolerant crops, micro-irrigation, soil monitoring and weather advisories can reduce climate-sensitive farm losses. Micro-irrigation, soil monitoring and weather advisories can reduce exposure when they fit local crops and water conditions. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the agriculture illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

At the institutional level, **distributed energy** gives the argument a distinct job. Decentralised renewable systems and storage can support essential services when central networks fail. The Ahmedabad Heat Action Plan illustrates how forecasting, public communication and local health protocols can work together. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the heat illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

The argument becomes deeper when, **water security** gives the argument a distinct job. Wastewater reuse, aquifer monitoring, rainwater harvesting and efficient treatment expand local buffers. Odisha's preparedness experience shows that warnings matter only when shelters, local administration and evacuation capacity connect to them. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the cyclones illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

An Indian illustration clarifies this, **risk information** gives the argument a distinct job. Remote sensing, forecasting and last-mile warning systems improve preparedness only when alerts are trusted and actionable. Decentralised solar systems can keep essential services functioning where a central grid is disrupted. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the energy illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

Yet breadth without qualification is unsafe, **climate-resilient settlements** gives the argument a distinct job. Cool roofs, passive design, permeable surfaces and nature-based drainage can reduce heat and flood exposure. Rainwater harvesting, watershed work and mangrove protection combine engineered and nature-based resilience. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the water and ecology illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

A further dimension concerns distribution, **justice and capability** gives the argument a distinct job. Open standards, local repair skills, finance and public procurement determine whether vulnerable communities can use the technology. Local repair skills, affordable finance and public procurement determine whether vulnerable communities can actually use a technology. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the justice illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

The strongest counter-view cannot be hidden in a token sentence. Expensive imported systems, energy-intensive solutions and poorly governed infrastructure can create new dependencies or shift risk elsewhere. This objection matters because it prevents the essay from turning a suggestive proposition into an absolute one. It also forces a distinction between necessary and sufficient conditions: the central idea may explain an important part of the outcome without exhausting every material, institutional or historical cause. A credible essay absorbs this challenge and narrows its claim rather than dismissing it.

A qualified synthesis now becomes possible. The competing positions are not simply split into a mechanical 'both sides' balance. Instead, the essay asks when the main proposition is persuasive, which safeguards or capabilities make it constructive, and when its apparent wisdom becomes exclusion, passivity or overstatement. This move preserves the moral and philosophical force of the prompt while grounding it in Indian constitutional values, public institutions and everyday experience.

India needs not a catalogue of futuristic devices but a resilient technology ecosystem joining science, local institutions, ecological wisdom and equitable access. The conclusion earns its place because it does not add a new catalogue. It returns to the exact proposition after the argument has changed its meaning: the opening claim is now bounded by evidence, counter-view and conditions. That movement from assertion to qualified understanding is what distinguishes an Essay argument from a GS answer arranged under many headings.

Paragraph-level reasoning

Paragraph	Argument job	Construction
1	Resilient agriculture	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
2	Distributed energy	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
3	Water security	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
4	Risk information	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
5	Climate-resilient settlements	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
6	Justice and capability	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation

Evidence and example audit

- **Agriculture:** Micro-irrigation, soil monitoring and weather advisories can reduce exposure when they fit local crops and water conditions.
- **Heat:** The Ahmedabad Heat Action Plan illustrates how forecasting, public communication and local health protocols can work together.
- **Cyclones:** Odisha's preparedness experience shows that warnings matter only when shelters, local administration and evacuation capacity connect to them.
- **Energy:** Decentralised solar systems can keep essential services functioning where a central grid is disrupted.
- **Water and ecology:** Rainwater harvesting, watershed work and mangrove protection combine engineered and nature-based resilience.
- **Justice:** Local repair skills, affordable finance and public procurement determine whether vulnerable communities can actually use a technology.

Counterargument and qualified synthesis

Counter-view: Expensive imported systems, energy-intensive solutions and poorly governed infrastructure can create new dependencies or shift risk elsewhere.

Synthesis rule: retain the insight, specify its conditions and show where an unqualified version becomes unjust, ineffective or incomplete.

Why this earns marks

- It answers the printed relationship rather than an adjacent topic.
- One thesis controls the outline and every paragraph performs a new job.
- India-centric examples are integrated through analysis, not dumped.
- The counter-view changes the thesis and leads to an earned synthesis.
- The conclusion returns to the prompt at a deeper, qualified level.

How to improve under exam conditions

- Replace any example you cannot state safely with a simpler verified one.
- Shorten descriptive setup before cutting analysis or qualification.
- Check that every transition explains why the next paragraph follows.
- Reserve the final minutes for prompt words, paragraph unity and risky attributions.

SOLVED ESSAY 2 - 2019-B7

Prompt

Biased media is a real threat to Indian democracy.

Verification and attribution boundary

Exact V1 wording; used to expose the evaluative standards behind real threat and Indian democracy. No author is attributed unless the audited paper itself prints one; this model uses no invented quotation, statistic, report or official marking rule.

Prompt interpretation

Identify the operative relation, surface its tension, state the scope and preserve one counter-reading. Do not replace the proposition with a broad GS subject label.

Central thesis

Biased media threatens Indian democracy when systematic distortion deprives citizens of reliable information, weakens scrutiny and polarises public reason, although viewpoint diversity must be protected and bias distinguished from mere disagreement.

Complete outline

1. **Informed citizenship:** Elections are meaningful only when citizens can evaluate competing claims through sufficiently reliable information.
2. **Accountability:** Selective silence or partisan framing can shield power and make public institutions less answerable.
3. **Polarisation:** Sensational and identity-driven coverage can replace deliberation with permanent mobilisation against imagined enemies.
4. **Ownership and incentives:** Concentrated ownership, advertising dependence and attention metrics can shape editorial priorities without explicit censorship.
5. **Digital amplification:** Algorithmic distribution and misinformation accelerate biased narratives and blur the boundary between journalism and propaganda.
6. **Democratic safeguards:** Independent regulation, transparency, media literacy, plural ownership and strong public-interest journalism must coexist with free expression.

Full model essay - 1001 words

The statement, “Biased media is a real threat to Indian democracy.”, is not an invitation to display every fact associated with its nouns. It asks the writer to identify the relationship asserted by the sentence, test that relationship across different settings and arrive at a qualified judgment. Biased media threatens Indian democracy when systematic distortion deprives citizens of reliable information, weakens scrutiny and polarises public reason, although viewpoint diversity must be protected and bias distinguished from mere disagreement. The essay will therefore move from the central idea to its individual, institutional and public consequences, then confront the strongest limit before returning to an earned synthesis.

To begin with, **informed citizenship** gives the argument a distinct job. Elections are meaningful only when citizens can evaluate competing claims through sufficiently reliable information. Article 19(1)(a) protects expression because democratic choice requires citizens to receive and contest information. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the citizenship illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

At the institutional level, **accountability** gives the argument a distinct job. Selective silence or partisan framing can shield power and make public institutions less answerable. Investigative journalism and information obtained through the RTI framework can expose failures that official narratives omit. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the accountability illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

The argument becomes deeper when, **polarisation** gives the argument a distinct job. Sensational and identity-driven coverage can replace deliberation with permanent mobilisation against imagined enemies. Sensational coverage can convert social difference into permanent political suspicion and reward outrage over verification. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the polarisation illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

An Indian illustration clarifies this, **ownership and incentives** gives the argument a distinct job. Concentrated ownership, advertising dependence and attention metrics can shape editorial priorities without explicit censorship. Advertising dependence and attention metrics can shape editorial choices even without direct censorship. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the incentives illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

Yet breadth without qualification is unsafe, **digital amplification** gives the argument a distinct job. Algorithmic distribution and misinformation accelerate biased narratives and blur the boundary between journalism and propaganda. Community radio, regional media and public-interest journalism show why diversity of voice is a democratic resource. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the plurality illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

A further dimension concerns distribution, **democratic safeguards** gives the argument a distinct job. Independent regulation, transparency, media literacy, plural ownership and strong public-interest journalism must coexist with free expression. Transparency of ownership, professional correction, media literacy and independent oversight are safer than state-enforced uniformity. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the safeguards illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience

the same process differently.

The strongest counter-view cannot be hidden in a token sentence. Government control in the name of neutrality can itself become a greater democratic threat, and complete value-neutrality is neither possible nor desirable. This objection matters because it prevents the essay from turning a suggestive proposition into an absolute one. It also forces a distinction between necessary and sufficient conditions: the central idea may explain an important part of the outcome without exhausting every material, institutional or historical cause. A credible essay absorbs this challenge and narrows its claim rather than dismissing it.

A qualified synthesis now becomes possible. The competing positions are not simply split into a mechanical 'both sides' balance. Instead, the essay asks when the main proposition is persuasive, which safeguards or capabilities make it constructive, and when its apparent wisdom becomes exclusion, passivity or overstatement. This move preserves the moral and philosophical force of the prompt while grounding it in Indian constitutional values, public institutions and everyday experience.

The democratic objective is not a voicelessly neutral press but a plural, transparent and accountable media order in which facts remain contestable without becoming disposable. The conclusion earns its place because it does not add a new catalogue. It returns to the exact proposition after the argument has changed its meaning: the opening claim is now bounded by evidence, counter-view and conditions. That movement from assertion to qualified understanding is what distinguishes an Essay argument from a GS answer arranged under many headings.

Paragraph-level reasoning

Paragraph	Argument job	Construction
1	Informed citizenship	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
2	Accountability	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
3	Polarisation	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
4	Ownership and incentives	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
5	Digital amplification	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
6	Democratic safeguards	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation

Evidence and example audit

- **Citizenship:** Article 19(1)(a) protects expression because democratic choice requires citizens to receive and contest information.
- **Accountability:** Investigative journalism and information obtained through the RTI framework can expose failures that official narratives omit.
- **Polarisation:** Sensational coverage can convert social difference into permanent political suspicion and reward outrage over verification.
- **Incentives:** Advertising dependence and attention metrics can shape editorial choices even without direct censorship.
- **Plurality:** Community radio, regional media and public-interest journalism show why diversity of voice is a democratic resource.
- **Safeguards:** Transparency of ownership, professional correction, media literacy and independent oversight are safer than state-enforced uniformity.

Counterargument and qualified synthesis

Counter-view: Government control in the name of neutrality can itself become a greater democratic threat, and complete value-neutrality is neither possible nor desirable.

Synthesis rule: retain the insight, specify its conditions and show where an unqualified version becomes unjust, ineffective or incomplete.

Why this earns marks

- It answers the printed relationship rather than an adjacent topic.

- One thesis controls the outline and every paragraph performs a new job.
- India-centric examples are integrated through analysis, not dumped.
- The counter-view changes the thesis and leads to an earned synthesis.
- The conclusion returns to the prompt at a deeper, qualified level.

How to improve under exam conditions

- Replace any example you cannot state safely with a simpler verified one.
- Shorten descriptive setup before cutting analysis or qualification.
- Check that every transition explains why the next paragraph follows.
- Reserve the final minutes for prompt words, paragraph unity and risky attributions.

SOLVED ESSAY 3 - 2024-B5

Prompt

Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth precipitating depression and loneliness.

Verification and attribution boundary

Exact V1 wording, including the missing comma before precipitating; used for a causal-chain scoping application. No author is attributed unless the audited paper itself prints one; this model uses no invented quotation, statistic, report or official marking rule.

Prompt interpretation

Identify the operative relation, surface its tension, state the scope and preserve one counter-reading. Do not replace the proposition with a broad GS subject label.

Central thesis

Social media can intensify FOMO by turning social comparison into a continuous, quantified and commercially amplified experience, yet youth distress arises from the interaction of platform design, social conditions and individual vulnerability rather than technology alone.

Complete outline

1. **Comparison architecture:** Curated highlights make ordinary life appear deficient and convert belonging into a visible competition for attention.
2. **Attention economy:** Notifications, streaks and algorithmic recommendation reward repeated checking and make absence feel like social loss.
3. **Loneliness paradox:** High connectivity can coexist with weak intimacy when interaction is performative, fragmented or measured through public approval.
4. **Unequal vulnerability:** Adolescents facing exclusion, academic pressure or weak support systems may experience the same platforms more harmfully.
5. **Positive capability:** Online communities can also provide expression, learning and support, especially where offline opportunities are limited.
6. **Shared responsibility:** Digital literacy, humane platform design, family communication, counselling and accessible mental-health services must work together.

Full model essay - 1022 words

The statement, "Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth precipitating depression and loneliness.", is not an invitation to display every fact associated with its nouns. It asks the writer to identify the relationship asserted by the sentence, test that relationship across different settings and arrive at a qualified judgment. Social media can intensify FOMO by turning social comparison into a continuous, quantified and commercially amplified experience, yet youth distress arises from the interaction of platform design, social conditions and individual vulnerability rather than technology alone. The essay will therefore move from the central idea to its individual, institutional and public consequences, then confront the strongest limit before returning to an earned synthesis.

To begin with, **comparison architecture** gives the argument a distinct job. Curated highlights make ordinary life appear deficient and convert belonging into a visible competition for attention. Curated peer feeds in schools and

colleges can make ordinary study, friendship and leisure appear inadequate. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the comparison illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

At the institutional level, **attention economy** gives the argument a distinct job. Notifications, streaks and algorithmic recommendation reward repeated checking and make absence feel like social loss. Notifications, streaks and public counts turn attention into a visible contest and make disconnection feel costly. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the design illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

The argument becomes deeper when, **loneliness paradox** gives the argument a distinct job. High connectivity can coexist with weak intimacy when interaction is performative, fragmented or measured through public approval. Online contact can widen networks while still failing to provide the trust and presence associated with close friendship. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the belonging illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

An Indian illustration clarifies this, **unequal vulnerability** gives the argument a distinct job. Adolescents facing exclusion, academic pressure or weak support systems may experience the same platforms more harmfully. Academic pressure, exclusion and weak family support can intensify the same platform experience for some adolescents. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the vulnerability illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

Yet breadth without qualification is unsafe, **positive capability** gives the argument a distinct job. Online communities can also provide expression, learning and support, especially where offline opportunities are limited. Online learning groups and support communities show that digital connection can also reduce isolation. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the capability illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

A further dimension concerns distribution, **shared responsibility** gives the argument a distinct job. Digital literacy, humane platform design, family communication, counselling and accessible mental-health services must work together. Digital literacy, counselling, family dialogue and humane platform design distribute responsibility beyond the individual user. This example is useful not because it is decorative, but because it shows a mechanism: choices, institutions or incentives convert an abstract proposition into a lived consequence. The paragraph should therefore connect the response illustration back to the controlling thesis. Its limit must also remain visible: one example establishes a plausible route, not a universal law, and a different social position may experience the same process differently.

The strongest counter-view cannot be hidden in a token sentence. Blaming social media alone ignores family stress, unemployment, educational pressure and pre-existing mental-health conditions. This objection matters because it prevents the essay from turning a suggestive proposition into an absolute one. It also forces a distinction between necessary and sufficient conditions: the central idea may explain an important part of the outcome without exhausting every material, institutional or historical cause. A credible essay absorbs this challenge and narrows its claim rather than dismissing it.

A qualified synthesis now becomes possible. The competing positions are not simply split into a mechanical 'both sides' balance. Instead, the essay asks when the main proposition is persuasive, which safeguards or capabilities make it constructive, and when its apparent wisdom becomes exclusion, passivity or overstatement. This move

preserves the moral and philosophical force of the prompt while grounding it in Indian constitutional values, public institutions and everyday experience.

The answer is neither digital abstinence nor technological fatalism, but an online environment in which connection serves human relationships instead of converting them into an endless status contest. The conclusion earns its place because it does not add a new catalogue. It returns to the exact proposition after the argument has changed its meaning: the opening claim is now bounded by evidence, counter-view and conditions. That movement from assertion to qualified understanding is what distinguishes an Essay argument from a GS answer arranged under many headings.

Paragraph-level reasoning

Paragraph	Argument job	Construction
1	Comparison architecture	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
2	Attention economy	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
3	Loneliness paradox	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
4	Unequal vulnerability	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
5	Positive capability	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation
6	Shared responsibility	Distinct claim -> named illustration -> mechanism -> limitation

Evidence and example audit

- **Comparison:** Curated peer feeds in schools and colleges can make ordinary study, friendship and leisure appear inadequate.
- **Design:** Notifications, streaks and public counts turn attention into a visible contest and make disconnection feel costly.
- **Belonging:** Online contact can widen networks while still failing to provide the trust and presence associated with close friendship.
- **Vulnerability:** Academic pressure, exclusion and weak family support can intensify the same platform experience for some adolescents.
- **Capability:** Online learning groups and support communities show that digital connection can also reduce isolation.
- **Response:** Digital literacy, counselling, family dialogue and humane platform design distribute responsibility beyond the individual user.

Counterargument and qualified synthesis

Counter-view: Blaming social media alone ignores family stress, unemployment, educational pressure and pre-existing mental-health conditions.

Synthesis rule: retain the insight, specify its conditions and show where an unqualified version becomes unjust, ineffective or incomplete.

Why this earns marks

- It answers the printed relationship rather than an adjacent topic.
- One thesis controls the outline and every paragraph performs a new job.
- India-centric examples are integrated through analysis, not dumped.
- The counter-view changes the thesis and leads to an earned synthesis.
- The conclusion returns to the prompt at a deeper, qualified level.

How to improve under exam conditions

- Replace any example you cannot state safely with a simpler verified one.
- Shorten descriptive setup before cutting analysis or qualification.
- Check that every transition explains why the next paragraph follows.

- Reserve the final minutes for prompt words, paragraph unity and risky attributions.

EXECUTABLE EXAM STRATEGY

The printed paper rule controls; the schedule below is a candidate strategy and must be adjusted to handwriting speed.

Phase	Suggested time	Risk control
Read both Sections and choose a pair	10 minutes	Confirm one prompt from each Section; reject unsafe attribution/data dependence
Plan Essay 1	15 minutes	Restatement, thesis, 6-8 paragraph jobs, evidence and counter-view
Draft Essay 1	65 minutes	Keep paragraph unity and transitions visible
Revise Essay 1	5 minutes	Prompt words, evidence, repetition and conclusion
Plan Essay 2	15 minutes	Re-run the same gates independently
Draft Essay 2	65 minutes	Protect analysis from late fact-dumping
Revise Essay 2	5 minutes	Attribution, coherence and unfinished sentences

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ESSAY

Subject: Essay | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** Essay (General Studies Paper - Essay, Mains). **Core area:** The scope-discipline that separates an issue-based essay from a GS answer; distributional and mechanism-level analysis of the FOMO/social-media prompt as the corpus's clearest test case. **Grounded in:** UPSC Essay PYQ corpus - V1 directly verified locally for 2018-2025 and V2 carried-forward practice wording for 2013-2017 (see ../PYQ-Corpus-2013-2025.md); ../00_Master-Framework.md Section 4. **Research cutoff:** 18 July 2026. **Tags:** FACT: verified fact | ANALYSIS: strategy/inference | CURRENT: dated anchor | WRONG: trap/boundary. **Companion:** ../basic/03_Issue-Based-Prompt-Scoping.md

1. Advanced proposition and boundary

Proposition: ANALYSIS: an issue-based essay prompt differs from a GS answer not in subject matter but in *test-of-argument* - the examiner already expects the candidate to know the phenomenon; what is tested is whether the candidate can build a qualified thesis and a synthesis around it. **Boundary:** WRONG: this topic does not supply the platform-design or mental-health mechanism content itself in GS depth (owned by Indian-Society and Science-and-Technology); it supplies the essay-specific scoping discipline that keeps that content in service of an argument.

2. Concept definition and taxonomy

- **Issue-statement prompt:** names phenomenon + mechanism + consequence in one sentence (2024-B5 is the corpus's example).
- **Scope creep:** essay drifts from the *specific* asserted mechanism ("FOMO... precipitating depression and loneliness") into a general survey of "social media in society."
- **GS-answer collapse:** headings, "causes/effects/measures" structure, and scheme-name lists substituted for continuous argument.
- **ANALYSIS:** Note the taxonomy is not unique to 2024-B5 - any future issue-style prompt (on, say, urbanisation, automation, or misinformation) should be scoped by the same method.

3. Tension pairs and hidden assumptions

- **Causal specificity vs. generality:** the prompt asserts a specific mechanism (FOMO precipitating depression/loneliness); the hidden assumption in a weak essay is that any social-media-related content answers the question - it does not, unless it engages that specific causal chain.
- **Universality vs. distribution:** "the youth" is treated as homogeneous by the prompt's phrasing; an advanced essay should interrogate this - access, platform type, family context, and pre-existing vulnerability all mediate the effect differently.
- **Correlation vs. mechanism:** a common hidden assumption is that observed association between usage and distress implies the causal story asserted by the prompt; an advanced essay should explicitly discuss plausible mechanism (social comparison, curated self-presentation, algorithmic amplification of engagement) rather than assert correlation as proof.

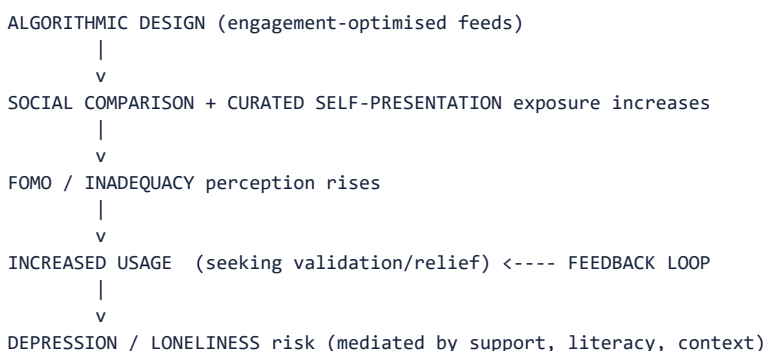
4. Levels of analysis and temporal-spatial scale

Level	What the essay should say at this level
Individual	Social comparison, self-esteem, validation-seeking behaviour
Family/community	Parental mediation, peer culture, offline-relationship displacement
Institutional/platform	Design incentives (engagement metrics), content-recommendation systems
State/policy	Digital literacy programmes, platform-accountability debate, age-appropriate design
Temporal	Whether the effect is a stable feature of always-on connectivity or an artefact of a particular platform-design era, subject to future design change

5. Stakeholder map and distributional effects

ANALYSIS: Distinguish: (a) youth users directly affected; (b) platforms whose business model may depend on engagement-maximising design; (c) families and schools bearing mediation responsibility; (d) the state, balancing free expression against protective regulation. An advanced essay should show that responsibility is distributed across these actors, rather than locating blame in only one (e.g. "youth today" moralising, or purely "Big Tech" moralising) - both are one-sided versions of the same scope-collapse error.

6. Causality, mechanisms and feedback loops



ANALYSIS: The feedback loop (increased distress driving increased, not decreased, usage) is the analytically richest part of this prompt - naming it distinguishes an advanced essay from one that treats the relationship as simple and linear.

7. Necessary/sufficient conditions and exceptions

ANALYSIS: Social media use is not sufficient by itself to cause depression/ loneliness - the mechanism is mediated by design, context, and pre-existing vulnerability (Section 4); nor is abstinence necessary for protection - supportive use (e.g. maintaining distant relationships, accessing peer support) can supply a counter-case. An advanced essay states this precisely rather than treating the prompt's claim as an absolute law to be defended or attacked wholesale.

8. Paradox, dialectic and counterfactual test

Paradox: the same technology that promises connection can produce isolation - not a contradiction, but a double effect depending on use pattern and design. **Dialectic:** thesis (connectivity precipitates distress) -> counter-claim (connectivity also provides support, information and civic voice) -> condition (effect depends on design and use-pattern) -> synthesis (agency, literacy and humane platform design as joint correctives). **Counterfactual test:** "If platforms were designed without engagement-maximising feeds, would the FOMO mechanism (Section

6. still operate at the same intensity?" - a "no" strengthens the design-focused thesis; a "largely yes" strengthens a thesis centred on underlying social-comparison psychology.

9. Ethical conflict and synthesis

ANALYSIS: Values in tension: individual autonomy and free expression vs. protective regulation of minors; platform commercial interest vs. user well-being; parental oversight vs. adolescent privacy. **Synthesis:** locate responsibility across the distributed stakeholder map (Section

5. - literacy and self-regulation at the individual/family level, accountable design at the platform level, and proportionate, rights-respecting safeguards at the policy level - rather than resolving the conflict by favouring one actor's interest alone.

10. Evidence/source-risk and India application

FACT: The prompt itself supplies no statistic and no author; an advanced essay should resist supplying an invented one either. ANALYSIS: India application: use a named, verifiable Indian illustration where available; otherwise state the policy debate qualitatively without asserting an unverified national prevalence figure - full discipline in 09/12.

11. Advanced structure, paragraph sequencing and style

ANALYSIS: Recommended sequencing: phenomenon and tension (1 paragraph) -> mechanism and feedback loop (Section 6, 2 paragraphs) -> distributional analysis across stakeholders (Section 5, 1-2 paragraphs) -> counter-case and dialectic (Section 8, 1 paragraph) -> synthesis and forward-looking close (1 paragraph). This keeps the essay argumentative throughout, rather than descriptive-then-prescriptive in the GS-answer style.

12. WRONG: Failure modes and revision protocol

- WRONG: **Full GS-III/Society answer disguised as an essay** (headings, scheme lists). -> Protocol: remove all headings; verify every paragraph contains a claim, not just a fact.
- WRONG: **Treating "youth" as undifferentiated.** -> Protocol: qualify by at least one distributional variable (Section 5) in the essay body.
- WRONG: **Correlation-as-causation without mechanism.** -> Protocol: state the mechanism (Section 6) explicitly before asserting the causal claim.
- WRONG: **One-sided technology-moralising** (either "social media is simply bad" or "concerns are overblown"). -> Protocol: always include the dialectic step (Section 8) before the conclusion.

13. CURRENT: Dated anchor / practice lab / transfer task

CURRENT: Dated anchor: if a genuinely current, dated official statement on platform regulation or youth digital-safety policy is available and verifiable at the time of writing, it may be cited with its source and date; otherwise, describe the policy debate in general, undated terms rather than inventing a "latest" development.

Practice lab: Write the mechanism diagram (Section 6) and the distributional stakeholder list (Section 5) for 2024-B5 from memory in under 10 minutes, without consulting this file.

Transfer task: Apply the same scoping method (phenomenon -> mechanism -> distribution -> dialectic -> synthesis) to a hypothetical future issue-style prompt (e.g. on automation or misinformation) to confirm the method generalises beyond this one audited prompt.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018, 2019, 2020, 2023
- **Paper(s):** Essay
- **Routed question demands:** 9

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	Essay	1	Alternative technologies for a climate change resilient India	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2018	Essay	4	Management of Indian border disputes as a complex task	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2019	Essay	5	South Asian societies woven around plural cultures and identities	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2019	Essay	6	Neglect of primary health care and education as reasons for backwardness	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2019	Essay	7	Biased media as a real threat to Indian democracy	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2019	Essay	8	Rise of Artificial Intelligence, jobless future or reskilling opportunity	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2020	Essay	7	Patriarchy as the least noticed structure of social inequality	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.
2020	Essay	8	Technology as the silent factor in international relations	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2023	Essay	5	Girls weighed down by restrictions and boys by demands	Essay · 125 marks · 1000-1200 words	Method routing only; prompt content is not pre-taught anywhere in this kit	Use as a brainstorming/theme test; this owner supplies essay method, not a model essay.

What this owner must now support

- Alternative technologies for a climate change resilient India
- Management of Indian border disputes as a complex task
- South Asian societies woven around plural cultures and identities
- Neglect of primary health care and education as reasons for backwardness
- Biased media as a real threat to Indian democracy
- Rise of Artificial Intelligence, jobless future or reskilling opportunity
- Patriarchy as the least noticed structure of social inequality
- Technology as the silent factor in international relations
- Girls weighed down by restrictions and boys by demands

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REVISION GUIDE

Rapid recall

Issue-Based Prompt Scoping: DEMAND, OBJECT AND QUALIFIER SCOPE MAP

1. **Issue-statement prompt:** An issue prompt names a real phenomenon and makes a causal, comparative, interrogative or evaluative claim that can be contested without first decoding a dominant metaphor.
2. **Classification gate:** A prompt is scoped as an issue when it names a concrete phenomenon, asserts something about it and already yields a literal contestable proposition.
3. **Directive or demand:** Identify whether the wording asks a question, presents alternatives, asserts causation or makes a value judgment; that demand governs the essay's argumentative burden.
4. **Object:** The object is the precise phenomenon or relationship being examined, not the entire GS subject area surrounding it.
5. **Qualifier:** Words such as Indian, majority, youth, real, complex, alternative or better narrow the claim and must survive in the thesis.
6. **Geography:** State whether the prompt is bounded to India, South Asia, another named region or a wider frame; do not globalise or nationalise it automatically.
7. **Time:** Distinguish a present condition, historical change, future possibility or long-run consequence when the wording supports that temporal boundary.
8. **Actor:** Identify who acts, experiences, decides, benefits or bears cost, and do not treat a broad group such as youth or farmers as homogeneous.
9. **Scale:** Locate the demand at individual, community, institutional, state, regional or global scale before importing examples from another level.
10. **Causal demand:** Where the prompt asserts causation, test each link through mechanism, evidence, mediator and limit instead of merely repeating the causal words.
11. **Evaluative demand:** Where the prompt uses judgment terms such as threat, anomaly, myth, reality or complex, define the standard by which the judgment will be assessed.

12. **Hidden tension:** Issue prompts normally contain a trade-off or double effect that must be made explicit, such as connection versus isolation or automation versus reskilling.
13. **Excluded material:** Write a negative boundary naming adjacent content that will not enter unless it directly advances the exact prompt.
14. **Definition boundary:** Define only the terms needed to fix the proposition; a long textbook background section expands the topic before the thesis is secure.
15. **Thesis boundary:** The thesis must answer the prompt's exact causal or evaluative claim with stated conditions, not announce that the issue has both advantages and disadvantages.
16. **Scope creep:** Scope creep occurs when the response becomes a general survey of the domain instead of testing the prompt's specified relationship.
17. **GS-answer collapse:** A causes-effects-measures or scheme catalogue does not by itself create a sustained Essay argument, even when every listed fact is accurate.
18. **Policy-catalogue avoidance:** Policies and institutions should appear as evidence for a claim, mechanism or synthesis, never as an isolated inventory of government action.
19. **Counter-case:** The strongest rival or beneficial effect should be stated fairly and used to qualify the thesis rather than appended as token balance.
20. **Synthesis:** A good issue essay resolves the tension by distributing responsibility, specifying conditions and connecting feasible institutional action with agency and values.

Issue-Based Prompt Scoping: GEOGRAPHY, TIME, ACTOR, SCALE AND EXCLUSION FIREWALLS

- Do not scope a metaphor-heavy hybrid as a literal issue statement before decoding it.
- Do not ignore interrogative, causal, comparative or evaluative wording.
- Do not drop qualifiers such as India, youth, majority or long run.
- Do not shift geography, actor, time or scale without explaining the move.
- Do not present association as causation without a mechanism and mediator.
- Do not define the whole subject when only one relationship is contested.
- Do not convert the essay into a scheme or policy catalogue.
- Do not treat a broad social group as internally uniform.
- Do not add a token counterpoint after a one-sided essay.
- Do not end with generic balance; state the conditions of synthesis.

Issue-Based Prompt Scoping: CAUSAL OR EVALUATIVE THESIS-TO-SYNTHESIS SPINE

CLASSIFY THE PROMPT

- > IDENTIFY DIRECTIVE OR ASSERTED DEMAND
- > LOCK OBJECT QUALIFIER GEOGRAPHY TIME ACTOR AND SCALE
- > TEST CAUSAL LINKS OR EVALUATIVE STANDARD
- > NAME HIDDEN TENSION AND EXCLUDED MATERIAL
- > WRITE A CONDITIONAL THESIS
- > COUNTER-CASE THEN SYNTHESIS WITHOUT POLICY CATALOGUE

Issue-Based Prompt Scoping: V1 ISSUE-PROMPT WORDING AND LIVE-SOURCE BOUNDARY

The 2026-09-04 official-site attempts supplied no new content. Prompt wording and metadata remain bounded by local V1 papers and the audited Essay corpus; issue analysis is explicitly repository-authored method.

Final 90-second check

1. Exact proposition answered, not an adjacent GS topic.
2. One qualified thesis controls every paragraph.
3. Examples are accurate, attributable and analytically integrated.
4. Counter-view changes the thesis rather than appearing ceremonially.
5. Transitions explain progression; conclusion returns at a deeper level.